

Airtel Digital TV: 20 percent (Source: Media Partners Asia) – HD is now being offered by majority of the players. Mainstream channels are slowly going HD as well.

Buying a DTH service today can be a nightmarish experience, thanks to the insane variety of packages on offer. You need to choose wisely, based on your needs and budget. But at the same time, you should not be swayed by tall claims. This is where we come in, to guide you to make the best choice. We will also debunk some tall claims, along the way.

We got set-top boxes from five HD-DTH service providers such as Tata Sky, Airtel, Videocon, Reliance and Sun Direct. Dish TV did not want to participate, but being India's oldest DTH provider, we felt the need to include it, and decided to buy it ourselves. So let's see which service offers the best bang for your buck.

The HD-DTH Digital Video Recorders **Tata Sky+ HD**

The user interface is slightly different from the one found on Tata Sky DTH. The blue UI is replaced by a black colour. The fonts on this user interface appear much better than other service providers, which have a lot of jagged edges. Sun Direct HD was the only other service provider with neat fonts.

The layout of the remote control is the best we have seen among all the service providers. It has large distinctly shaped buttons for certain functions, so you can blindly operate the remote control. Placement of buttons is also well thought out, with the

four-way arrow buttons in the centre, surrounded by volume and channel controllers. There are direct shortcut buttons for Guide, Showcase, Organiser and Active services. Sadly, it's not a universal remote.

Guide brings up a list of genres to ease the channel selection. You can simply select a genre and you will be shown a row which will show five channels along with the program guide. Reminders can be set and a program can be assigned to be recorded, after entering information.

The DVR on Tata Sky + HD has a 500GB hard disk which allows you to record 600+ hours of TV programming. You can record two channels at a time, but will have to watch the second channel as it will not allow you to change channels. You can watch a recorded show while two channels are recording.

You can also enter the time from which you want to play-back your recorded material which is great if you

have recorded long duration content, but missed only the latter half.

Along with recording, it offers an option called Series Link which allows you to record your favourite show every time it airs, although its implementation is still dicey with some shows being dropped from being recorded randomly.

Tata Sky gives you the option to add 50 favourite chan-

HOW WE TESTED

We setup all the necessary boxes in our test lab and hooked them up with LG 47LX9500 3D LED TV. We used this 3D TV because we had a contender which beams 3D channels. All the set top boxes were activated with the highest plan on offer on a particular DTH service, as we wanted to test all the possible features.

The total evaluation was split up into four parameters: Features, Ease of Use, Performance and Costing. We checked the features offered by all the services, as listed in our table. While testing the Ease of Use, we tested the user friendliness of the system, as this a product that any member of the family should be able to operate with ease. Layout of remote control buttons, on-screen user interface, ease of navigating, etc. was taken into account. We also noted how easy or difficult it was to make changes in the settings menu for various features on offer. Performance parameters such as quality of HD content, responsiveness of the user interface, recording performance (for HD-DVR boxes) was measured. We connected four services at a time using the 4 HDMI outs on the TV and switched between them to do a comparative quality testing. As costing plays a very important role in this category, we calculated how much it would cost to own an HD-DTH service from scratch for the first year, having all the channels offered including HD channels. This was the Total Cost of Ownership which we used to find the Best Buy winners.

For the HD Digital Video Recorders, we tested the ease of recording content, accessing recorded content, scheduling recordings of future programs, padding time before and after a recording, etc.

nels, but it can be added under one profile only. So say you are a sports fanatic and set all the sports channels as favourites, then another member in your family will have to use this same profile and

change the channel, the buffer is lost. You can also record upto 30 mins before and after the scheduled record.

Tata Sky+ HD is currently the only service offering only true high definition channels and not upscaled ones. The picture quality on the 47-inch screen we were testing it on was flawless. Although standard definition content went for a toss. We tried changing the aspect ratio to 4:3, which improved the quality marginally. Quality of the Active Services was not so great as there was a lot of pixelation on our 47-inch screen, which kills the whole experience.

Videocon d2h 3D HD DVR

The only service provider with 3D capability, Videocon has a unique offering in addition to other HD DVRs. With time we are sure the others will also catch up. In fact



Tata Sky+ HD has the most impressive features and is a great performer as a normal DTH service as well as recording. It is our Best Performer

add their favourite channels after yours. Another interesting aspect is the buffering of the present channel content. You can replay a particular scene by pressing rewind. Once you